ROSAPAPAN, JEFFERSON BSIT2A

ETHIC ESSAY

In the context of Filipino culture, it is not ethically justifiable to treat children as a "retirement plan," although children may voluntarily support their parents out of love, gratitude, and family solidarity. In the Philippines, close family ties are highly valued, and many children grow up with the belief that they should help their parents once they become financially stable. This belief is often connected to the concept of *utang na loob*, which means a deep sense of gratitude for sacrifices made by parents in raising and educating their children. Since parents often endure hardship to provide food, shelter, and education, it is natural for children to feel a moral desire to give back. However, gratitude should come from free choice, not from pressure or obligation. When parents demand financial support as if it is automatically owed to them, *utang na loob* can be misused and become emotional manipulation instead of genuine appreciation.

Personal autonomy is another important ethical principle. Every child, even as an adult, has the right to make decisions about their own life, career, finances, and future family. If children are expected to fully carry their parents' financial burdens, their freedom may be limited. Many Filipino workers delay personal goals such as saving money, buying a home, pursuing higher education, or starting their own family because they must prioritize supporting parents and siblings. While helping family is noble, forcing children into that role may create resentment, stress, and a cycle of dependency. Parents have a responsibility to prepare for their own future as much as possible through savings, insurance, investments, or wise financial planning rather than assuming their children will provide everything.

At the same time, intergenerational responsibility should not be ignored. Families naturally care for one another across generations. Just as parents care for children when they are young, children may choose to care for aging parents when they become vulnerable. This mutual support is ethical when based on compassion, respect, and shared responsibility. It becomes unhealthy only when one generation sacrifices excessively while the other refuses accountability. Support should therefore be balanced, realistic, and according to the child's capacity. Helping with medical bills, daily needs, or companionship can be morally admirable, but expecting children to become the sole source of retirement income is unfair.

Personally, I believe children should not be considered a retirement plan because they are individuals with their own dreams and responsibilities, not financial investments. Parents raise children primarily out of love and duty, not for future profit. If children choose to help their parents later in life, that support should be seen as an act of gratitude and love, not repayment of debt. A healthy Filipino family culture should preserve respect for elders while also respecting the independence of the younger generation. In conclusion, children should never be treated as retirement plans, but they can become a source of support when family relationships are built on love, responsibility, and mutual care.